As I expected, a few days after the election Gromyko said he wanted to meet with George in Geneva to discuss holding a new round of arms control talks.

George agreed and a meeting was set for January.

Following the election, I also got a very unusual message congratulating me on my reelection: Scrawled by hand in Russian on a tiny piece of tissue paper about half the size of a business card, in characters so small a microscope was almost necessary to read them, the message came from ten women who were imprisoned at a Soviet forced-labor camp.

Mr. President:

We, women political prisoners of the Soviet Union, congratulate you on your reelection to the spot of President of the USA. We look with hope to your country which is on the road of FREEDOM and respect for HUMAN RIGHTS. We wish you success on this road.

With their message was a poem and a chart that listed a series of hunger strikes these brave women had conducted at their camp in 1983 and 1984 in defiance of a cruel regime that threw people in jail simply because they expressed a belief in freedom or said they wanted to emigrate from Russia for religious reasons. The material had been smuggled out of the camp and then out of Russia and delivered to the offices of Radio Free Europe in Munich. This is a translation of the poem they sent to me:

On the day of your election
There we were, in deep dejection,
In a filthy prison cell
Freezing cold and most unwell.
We did not have books or papers
Warming food or legal status,
Only frigid wind and stars
Through the naked window bars,